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Making Sense of Violence: Perceived Meaningfulness as a Predictor of Audience Interest in Violent Media Content

Anne Bartsch[1] & Marie-Louise Mares[2]

1 Department of Communication Studies and Media Research, LMU Munich Munich, 80538, Germany
2 Department of Communication Arts, University of Wisconsin Madison, Madison, WI 53706, USA

Research on audience interest in violent media content is extended to include individuals' appreciation of certain types of violent portrayals as a meaningful and valuable reflection of reality. A sample of 482 German and U.S. adults aged 18–82 watched movie trailers that varied in pretest ratings of gore and meaningfulness, but were equivalent in suspense. As hypothesized, perceived levels of gore and meaningfulness interacted to predict individuals' reported likelihood of watching the full movie, such that a negative influence of gore on viewing likelihood was compensated at high levels of meaningfulness. These findings suggest that, in addition to other motivations such as suspense, some types of violent and even gory content might be sought as an opportunity for meaning-making.

Keywords: Media Violence, Viewing Interest, Hedonic Enjoyment, Eudaimonic Appreciation, Meaning-Making, Suspense.

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Why do audiences watch scenes of bloodshed and aggression? A recent meta-analysis by Weaver (2011), based on 40 years of research, suggests that on the one hand, the presence of violence increases selective exposure to media content, but on the other hand, violence detracts from enjoyment while viewing. This study is intended to provide additional insight into this seemingly paradoxical pattern of viewing behavior. If they do not enjoy the depiction of blood and gore per se, what do viewers actually seek when exposing themselves to gory portrayals?

A growing body of research suggests that violence is not intrinsically appealing for most audiences but that it increases exposure indirectly, because it signals the presence of other desirable content characteristics and viewing experiences, such as thrill and suspense (e.g., Oliver, Kalyanaraman, Mahood, & Ramasubramanian, 2007; Valkenburg & Cantor, 2000; Zillmann, 1998). This project aims to extend this line of research

Correspondence author: Anne Bartsch; e-mail: anne.bartsch@ifkw.lmu.de

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with a special focus on nonhedonistic motivations that may also contribute to the attractions of violence in an indirect manner. Building on recent conceptualizations of eudaimonic, "meaning-making" motivations (Oliver & Bartsch, 2010; Oliver & Raney, 2011), we theorize that individuals may choose to watch violent, gory material if they anticipate that the depiction is a meaningful and valuable reflection of reality. While viewers might not enjoy watching a film about domestic abuse or the cruelties of war, they might nonetheless appreciate a serious and insightful reflection of these issues that acknowledges the human cost fully rather than eliding the violence.

As Weaver (2011) suggested, a richer understanding of the array of viewers' goals in seeking out violent content may allow producers to appeal to audiences in other ways, rather than simply escalating the degree of gore and bloodshed. Eudaimonic motivations such as the seeking of insight, meaning, and cognitive challenge might be of particular interest in this context because of their self-reflective and prosocial implications (Oliver & Bartsch, 2011; Oliver, Hartmann, & Woolley, 2012; Oliver & Raney, 2011). If such motivations play a significant role in raising audience interest in violent content, then they might counteract some of the negative, antisocial effects that media violence undoubtedly has (cf., Bushman & Huesmann, 2006).

Media violence: Selective exposure versus enjoyment

Industry lore has it that audiences — young men, in particular — want to see violence (Oliver et al., 2007; Weaver, 2011). Indeed, a content analysis by Oliver and Kalyanaraman (2002) found that movie trailers exaggerated the level of violence within the movies being previewed, presumably because the creators believed that doing so would enhance the film's appeal. The results of Weaver's (2011) meta-analysis suggest that those marketing films may be correct in thinking that violence increases attendance. Averaged across eight studies, involving a total of more than 1,000 participants, there was a small, significant, positive relationship ($r = .15$) between the presence of violence in media content and selective exposure to that content, as assessed by questions about the likelihood of viewing (i.e., attitudinal measures of selective exposure) or by actual viewing statistics (i.e., behavioral measures of selective exposure).

On the other hand, Weaver (2011) also found that this relationship was mirrored by a small, significant, negative relationship ($r = -.15$) between the presence of violence and self-reported enjoyment while viewing, assessed in 18 studies involving a total of more than 2,000 participants. When participants were experimentally assigned to watch content varying in levels of violence, those assigned to see less violence typically reported equivalent or higher rates of enjoyment (e.g., Diener & DeFour, 1978; Weaver & Wilson, 2009).

Responses to graphic gore

There is some indication that the negativity of responses to violent content varies by the degree of graphic gore. In an early study, Carruthers and Taggart (1973) observed relatively minimal physiological responses to scenes of mild, humorous violence, or suspense, but substantial changes in cardiac output and hormone levels after viewing

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extremely violent scenes from *A Clockwork Orange* or *Soldier Blue*. Harrison and Cantor (1999) found that scenes of blood, injections, or physical injury were listed most frequently by undergraduates who were asked to describe retrospectively the types of media content that had made them feel intensely frightened at some point in their past. Weaver and Wilson (2009) compared responses to unedited, graphic violence in programs such as *The Sopranos* and *24*, with edited versions of the same episodes that contained either mild, sanitized violence, or no violent images at all. They found that both the graphic and sanitized violence versions received lower ratings of enjoyment than the nonviolent versions, and that those who saw a graphic version reported higher levels of negative affect (e.g., disgust, shock, and anxiety).

Theorizing motives for viewing violent content: Co-occurring pleasures

How to reconcile these findings about selective exposure versus enjoyment? A common theme that emerges in many theories of the appeal of violence is that images of bloodshed and aggression are not intrinsically attractive to most audiences, but that there are other pleasures that accompany exposure to violence. Such explanations may be categorized into three interrelated categories.

One set of explanations focuses on gratifications related to *intense emotions and arousal*, such as voyeurism and curiosity about taboo actions (Sparks & Sparks, 2000), rebellious tasting of the "forbidden fruit" of violence (Bushman & Cantor, 2003), the intense absorption provided by highly engaging, arousing content (Goldstein, 1999), and the arousal-based enhancement of happy endings (Zillmann, 1998). Such gratifications related to arousal are often argued to be even more compelling for subgroups such as boys and young men, and sensation-seekers (see Hoffner & Levine, 2005, for meta-analytic findings). A second set of explanations focuses on *social gratifications*, such as bonding while viewing intensely disturbing material, or the playing out of traditional gender roles of masculine bravery and feminine timidity (Zillmann, Weaver, Mundorf, & Aust, 1986). A third set of explanations focuses on the *content features* that often accompany violence and that are argued to be the source of appeal, such as the pleasure of seeing villainous characters get punished and heroic figures get rewarded (see affective disposition theory, Raney & Bryant, 2002). Additionally, Wakshlag, Vial, and Tamborini (1983) reported that violence that is followed by the restoration of justice and order is appealing to those who are anxious about their own safety, because such material can offer vicarious relief from safety-related concerns. Other authors have noted the appeal of suspense, conflict, and action, all of which may co-occur with violence and which may explain why viewers seek out violent content (Valkenburg & Cantor, 2000; Vorderer & Knobloch, 2000).

Taken together, a growing body of evidence suggests that violence may increase viewing interest because it signals the presence of other desirable content characteristics and viewing experiences. Indeed, research by Oliver et al. (2007) found that the level of violence in movie previews did not enhance anticipated enjoyment directly, but instead did so indirectly by altering perceptions of other qualities of the films. That is, those who saw thriller previews containing more violence thought the films

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would be more suspenseful, and those who saw comedy previews with more violence thought the films would be more humorous. These perceptions, in turn, predicted anticipated enjoyment and desire to see the films.

The accounts discussed so far share a common focus on hedonic motivations. More precisely, they highlight hedonic pleasures, or sources of relief from unpleasant states, that do not reside in the violence itself but seem to contribute to the appeal of violent content in an indirect manner. But perhaps hedonic affect regulation is only part of the story about why we willingly expose ourselves to scenes of bloodshed and aggression. Recent theorizing and research on nonhedonistic motives for entertainment consumption may provide an innovative complementary approach to explaining attractions to violent content.

Theorizing nonhedonistic motives and responses

A growing body of theoretical and empirical evidence suggests that individuals' motivations for entertainment use may not only reflect hedonistic regulation of mood and arousal (cf., Zillmann, 1988; Zuckerman, 1979), but may also involve a search for deeper insight, meaning, and purpose in life (Cupchik, 1995; Oliver & Bartsch, 2010; Oliver & Raney, 2011; Tesser, Millar, & Wu, 1988; Wirth, Hofer, & Schramm, 2012). Drawing on the time-honored philosophical distinction between hedonic and eudaimonic happiness (i.e., happiness derived from pleasure vs. happiness derived from meaning and insight), Oliver and Raney (2011) conceptualized individuals' attractions to thought-provoking entertainment as a form of eudaimonic motivation, whereby viewers "search for and ponder life's meanings, truths, and purposes" (p. 985) (for related social psychological work on eudaimonic motivations see Ryff & Singer, 2008; Waterman, 1993).

Eudaimonic appreciation

The distinction between hedonic and eudaimonic motivations for entertainment consumption has also been linked to qualitatively different types of entertainment experiences that arise from the satisfaction of these needs. Hedonically rewarding experiences that are characterized by positive valence and pleasant arousal, such as amusement, thrill, and suspense, are usually subsumed under the concept of "enjoyment," whereas the experience of eudaimonic gratification has been conceptualized as "appreciation." Oliver and Bartsch (2010) described the defining characteristics of eudaimonic appreciation as: "an experiential state that is characterized by the perception of deeper meaning, the feeling of being moved, and the motivation to elaborate on thoughts and feelings inspired by the experience" (p. 76). Recent studies by Wirth et al. (2012) found that viewers' eudaimonic responses to sad films could be categorized in terms of gratifications derived from a deeper reflection on the film's meaning, and gratifications derived from thoughts about the viewer's own life.

Meaning-making as a motive for violence viewing?

These conceptualizations of eudaimonic appreciation are compatible with psychological theorizing and research on the processes by which individuals strive to make

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meaning out of negative experiences (Anderson & Kay, 2013; Park, 2010). According to this literature, the need for meaning-making is aroused by negative events that violate an individual's belief in the world as a just place where bad things do not happen to good people (including the self). In some cases, the cognitive dissonance resulting from unjust negative events is easily resolved by focusing on good things that happen to the same person later in life, such that the negative event is "balanced out." In the absence of material compensation, however, the process of dissonance reduction tends to focus on compensation in the realm of immaterial rewards such as deeper insight, social connection, and personal growth (Anderson & Kay, 2013).

Applied to the context of media violence, the meaning-making literature suggests that one motive for watching acts of violence perpetrated against likable characters on the screen may be the need to make sense of similar acts of violence in the real world that threaten the viewers' just-world beliefs. To the extent that a story highlights the compensation of victims in terms of immaterial rewards, the viewer's belief in a just world may be reinforced. Another, related motive may be to experience vicariously the character's process of meaning-making, and to generalize the insights gained from the story to negative experiences in one's own life. Research on eudaimonic entertainment has consistently found that viewers reflected not only about the deeper meaning of the content but also about the meaning of the content for their own life (Bartsch, 2012; Bartsch, Kalch, & Oliver, 2014; Cupchik, 1995; Knobloch-Westerwick, Gong, Hagner, & Kerbeykian, 2013; Oliver & Hartmann, 2010; Wirth et al., 2012).

The concept of immaterial rewards as described by theories of meaning-making (Anderson & Kay, 2013; Park, 2010), including experiences of deeper insight, social connection, and personal growth, is consistent with theories of eudaimonic motivation in general (Ryff & Singer, 2008; Waterman, 1993), and with theories of eudaimonic motivations for media use in particular (Oliver & Bartsch, 2010; Oliver & Raney, 2011; Wirth et al., 2012). Therefore, we propose to conceptualize individuals' experience of meaning-making in the context of media violence as a form of eudaimonic appreciation. The purpose of this study is to examine whether the anticipation of meaning-making and related eudaimonic responses may sometimes be a motive for viewing violence.

The current study

Perceived gore and meaningfulness as predictors of viewing interest

Taken together, the research reviewed above suggests that blood and gore are aversive rather than intrinsically appealing (e.g., Oliver & Sanders, 2003; Weaver & Wilson, 2009), and that exposure to such content may be driven less by viewers' interest in violence per se than by their seeking of other hedonistic types of gratifications such as arousal and suspense (e.g., Oliver et al., 2007; Zillmann, 1998). We suggest that the same logic applies to nonhedonistic motivations for viewing violent content: Individuals' negative responses to anticipated gore should be moderated by their perceptions of the content eliciting meaning-making responses and eudaimonic appreciation.

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To test these propositions, we conducted a study of individuals' perception of gore and meaningfulness in film trailers, and their interest in watching the full movie. We included films from different genres (action, horror, and drama) to maximize the variance of stimuli with regard to perceived levels of gore and meaningfulness. Participants watched one of four types of film trailers that differed in pretest ratings of gore (low vs. high) and meaningfulness (low vs. high). Given the well-documented effect of suspense on audience attraction to violent content, care was taken to keep suspense levels constant across the different types of trailers.

This study design allowed us to evaluate three propositions. The first (based on earlier findings of Oliver et al., 2007; Oliver & Sanders, 2003; Weaver & Wilson, 2009) was that high levels of gore are aversive rather than appealing if the level of suspense is held constant: The degree to which respondents perceive a movie to be gory, based on the movie trailer, will be negatively related to their reported likelihood of viewing the full movie, when suspensefulness is controlled (H1).

Second, based on research on eudaimonic motivations to seek out media content that elicits meaning-making responses (Oliver & Bartsch, 2010; Oliver & Raney, 2011), we predicted that the degree to which respondents perceive violent portrayals in a movie to be meaningful, based on the movie trailer, will be positively related to their reported likelihood of viewing the full movie (H2).

Third, and most relevant to our line of argument, we expected that perceived levels of gore and meaningfulness would interact in predicting viewing interest, because viewers may be willing to tolerate aversive experiences associated with gory portrayals if they feel that there is meaning in confronting these violent aspects of reality: Perceptions of gore and meaningfulness will interact such that the negative relationship of perceived gore with ratings of viewing likelihood is attenuated at high levels of perceived meaningfulness (H3).

Sample and control variables

Thus far, the focus has been on the influence of perceived gore and meaningfulness on ratings of viewing interest, averaged across individuals of different backgrounds. However, prior research and theorizing suggests that interest in viewing violent content may also depend on features of the individuals making the judgment, including their age, gender, level of education, cultural background, and prior exposure to horror films. For example, prior research has found that attraction to violent content was greater among *male viewers* (Hoffner & Levine, 2005), and among *adolescents and young adults* (Mares, Oliver, & Cantor, 2008; Mares & Sun, 2010; Tamborini & Stiff, 1987). In addition, research on desensitization suggests that *habitual viewers* of violence experience less anxious arousal and more pleasurable arousal when viewing graphic content than do other audience members (Krahé et al., 2011). Further, researchers have argued that violent content might be more attractive for those with *lower education* (Lemmens, Bushman, & Konijn, 2006), and those who grow up in a *cultural context where violent content is less regulated*, such as for instance the United States compared with Germany (Weaver, Brosius, & Mundorf, 1993), although

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evidence is less clear in these latter two cases. To control for the possible confounding influence of these individual difference variables, the study was conducted with a sample from Germany and the United States, representing a diversity of age groups, educational levels, and genre preferences. Age, gender, education, country, and prior interest in horror films were included as control variables in the statistical analyses.

Method

Design

To examine our hypotheses about the influence of perceived gore and meaningfulness on viewing interest, we conducted a study of individuals' perceptions of film trailers, and their reported likelihood of viewing the full movie. Participants of a binational sample from Germany and the United States were randomly assigned to rate one of four types of film trailers that varied in levels of gore and meaningfulness but were equally suspenseful according to pretest ratings.

Stimuli and pretest

Film trailers were used as stimuli to provide participants with a vivid impression of the target movies, such that they could make informed and ecologically valid decisions about their interest in watching the full movie. Twenty-four film trailers from different genres (horror, action and, drama) were pretested for perceived levels of gore, meaningfulness, and suspense, and for prior exposure. The pretest sample involved 187 students at a German university (76 male, 102 female, age: $M = 24.24$, $SD = 5.83$) and was divided into four groups of at least 40 participants, each of whom viewed and rated six trailers. Participants were asked whether they had seen the movie advertised in the trailer. Those who had seen the movie were asked to rate the movie, and those who had not seen the movie were asked to rate their impressions of the movie based on the trailer. For each trailer, five items were rated on a 7-point scale ranging from 1 (*not at all*) to 7 (*very much*): "this movie is … " "suspenseful," "gory," "brutal," and "the depiction of violence in this movie is … " "meaningful," "thought-provoking."

The trailers for the study were selected based on the following criteria: First, the difference of rating scores between those who had seen and who had not seen the movie needed to be small (less than 1 scale point) to make sure that the trailers conveyed an accurate impression of the movie. Second, averaged ratings of "gory"/"brutal" ($r = .78$), and "meaningful"/"thought-provoking" ($r = .74$) had to be clearly above or below the midpoint of the rating scale (i.e., smaller than 3, or greater than 5). Third, levels of suspense had to be roughly equivalent across all trailers selected for the main study (a mean score of about 5.5 scale points was chosen as the criterion here).

Based on these criteria, the following trailers were selected for the main study:

Film Type 1 (gore high, meaning high): *Saving Private Ryan*, *Hotel Rwanda*

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Film Type 2 (gore high, meaning low): *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre*, *The Hills Have Eyes*
Film Type 3 (gore low, meaning high): *A Beautiful Mind*, *The Green Mile*
Film Type 4 (gore low, meaning low): *Quantum of Solace*, *The Bourne Identity*

Participants

A total of 482 participants were recruited via a commercial online panel for market and social science research. They received a small financial reward for their participation. The sample consisted of 244 males, 234 females, and 4 who did not indicate their gender; 234 participants were from Germany and 248 participants were from the United States; 160 participants were young adults (age 18–25), 160 middle aged adults (age 26–49), and 161 older adults (age 50–82). The mean age of the overall sample was about 40 years ($M = 39.73$, $SD = 17.17$). The distribution of educational levels was comparable across national samples. Two thirds (65%) of both U.S. and German participants had at least completed high school and had been admitted to college or university. The remaining participants (35% of both German and U.S. samples) formed the comparison group labeled "basic education."

Procedure

Data were collected using an online survey. The survey started with an informed consent page explaining that the study was about viewers' perceptions of movie trailers, and that the trailers included in the survey had been approved for all audiences by the Motion Picture Association of America (MPAA). Participants were informed that they could skip the trailer, or any questions without losing the compensation offered. The consent page also included a short video clip, and asked participants to adjust their media player and sound settings before proceeding with the study. After participants signed in, they completed a background questionnaire on demographics and movie genre preferences and were randomly assigned to watch one of the eight stimulus trailers. After watching the film trailer, participants rated their perceptions of the trailer, and their likelihood of watching the full movie.

Measures

Demographics

The first section of the background questionnaire asked participants to provide basic demographic information (age, gender, and education).

Horror and other genre preferences

Also as part of the background questionnaire, participants rated their frequency of viewing and their liking of the following film genres: comedy, drama, action, thriller, war, and horror. For each genre, response options ranged from 1 (*never*) to 7 (*once a day or more*) and from 1 (*don't like at all*) to 7 (*like very much*). Based on these ratings, a measure of horror preference was created by calculating the mean score of liking and frequency ratings ($r = .85$).

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Expectations of the film
After watching the trailer, participants rated their expectations of the film. All ratings were recorded on 7-point scales ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 7 (*strongly agree*).

Expectations about violent portrayals in the movie: Gore and meaningfulness. Anticipated goriness was assessed with three items ("I think the movie would be … " "gory," "bloody," "brutal," United States: $\alpha = .94$, Germany: $\alpha = .94$). Anticipated meaningfulness of the film violence was measured with three items adapted from the eudaimonic appreciation scale of Oliver and Bartsch (2010). The original items ask about perceptions of a film as a whole. In this study, the scale item asked specifically about perceptions of the violence in the film ("I think the depiction of violence in this movie would be … " "meaningful," "moving," "thought-provoking"; United States: $\alpha = .92$, Germany: $\alpha = .90$). This eudaimonic appreciation variable is labeled "perceived meaningfulness."

Anticipated suspense and scariness. Anticipated suspense was assessed using the suspense scale of Oliver and Bartsch (2010; three items, e.g., "I think the movie would be suspenseful," "this movie would keep me at the edge of my seat"; United States: $\alpha = .91$, Germany: $\alpha = .86$). Anticipated fright reactions were assessed using three items ("I think the movie would be … " "frightening," "disturbing," "terrifying"; United States: $\alpha = .95$, Germany: $\alpha = .94$).

Likelihood of viewing the movie
Finally, participants were asked about their prior exposure to the movie ("Have you seen the movie advertised in this trailer?"), and how likely they would be to watch the full movie (three items, e.g., "After seeing the trailer, how much are you interested in seeing the full movie [or in seeing the movie again, in case you have already seen it]?" "After seeing the trailer, how willing would you be to see the movie [or to see the movie again] if friends asked you to go with them?"; 1 = "very unlikely," 7 = "very likely"; United States: $\alpha = .96$, Germany: $\alpha = .91$). Thus, our outcome measure assessed viewing interest as an attitude, rather than as a behavior. Despite the theoretical importance of this distinction, attitudinal and behavioral measures of selective exposure have empirically been found to yield comparable results, according to Weaver's (2011) meta-analysis of studies on selective exposure to violent content. Therefore, we opted for the less time-consuming alternative of measuring reported likelihood of viewing the movie rather than actual exposure in this study.

Stimulus check
To test whether the film trailers were associated with different levels of gore and meaningfulness and comparable levels of suspense as intended, a repeated measures ANCOVA was performed predicting participants' ratings of gore, meaning, and suspense as a function of film type, with age, gender, education, country, and prior exposure to the movie as covariates. This analysis revealed the expected Ratings by Film Condition interaction (Wilks's $\Lambda = 0.42$, $F(6, 882) = 79.41$, $\eta_p^2 = .35$, $p < .001$).

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In terms of *goriness*, the trailers in the high-gore group, Film Type 1 ($M = 4.98$, $SD = 1.40$) and Film Type 2 ($M = 6.01$, $SD = 1.25$), were rated significantly higher than the trailers in the low-gore group, Film Type 3 ($M = 2.70$, $SD = 1.64$) and Film Type 4 ($M = 3.84$, $SD = 1.55$; $p < .001$ for all pairwise comparisons of high- vs. low-gore conditions). In terms of *meaningfulness*, the trailers in the high-meaning group, Film Type 1 ($M = 5.84$, $SD = 1.48$) and Film Type 3 ($M = 5.72$, $SD = 1.34$), were rated significantly higher than the trailers in the low-meaning group, Film Type 2 ($M = 3.16$, $SD = 1.95$) and Film Type 4 ($M = 3.98$, $SD = 1.60$; $p < .001$ for all pairwise comparisons of high- vs. low-meaning conditions). *Suspense* ratings were constantly high, with no significant differences between film types: Film Type 1 ($M = 5.34$, $SD = 1.52$), Film Type 2 ($M = 4.98$, $SD = 1.76$), Film Type 3 ($M = 5.16$, $SD = 1.53$), and Film Type 4 ($M = 5.26$, $SD = 1.42$; $p > .05$ for all pairwise comparisons between conditions). Thus overall, stimulus sampling was effective in maximizing the variance in perceived levels of gore and meaningfulness, while keeping suspense levels constant across film types.

Results

To test our set of hypotheses concerning the influence of perceived gore and meaningfulness on individuals' reported likelihood of viewing the full movie, we performed a series of hierarchical regression analyses. In each of the four regression models, control variables were entered stepwise. In the final step, we entered our focal predictors (perceived gore and meaningfulness, and their interaction term) to examine their influence over and above the variance explained by the control variables. Table 1 shows the standardized regression weights and significance levels for each variable at the step they were entered.

Model 1: Perceived gore and meaningfulness as predictors of viewing interest (H1–H3)

Model 1 examined whether viewing interest was predicted by individual difference variables (Step 1), the control variables of prior exposure to the movie and anticipated suspensefulness of the movie (Step 2), and, finally, the focal predictors of perceived gore and meaningfulness (Step 3). As observed from Table 1, all three steps added significant amounts of variance. In the first step, participants from the United States and those who liked and frequently watched horror movies reported greater interest in watching the full movie advertised in the trailer they had seen. Age, gender, and education did not significantly predict viewing interest. In the second step, participants who had seen the movie before, and those who thought the movie would be more suspenseful reported greater viewing interest. In the third and final step, we entered our focal predictors, that is, perceptions of gore and meaningfulness, and their interaction term. As predicted, participants who perceived the movie to be less gory (H1) and those who perceived the movie to be more meaningful (H2) reported greater interest in viewing the full movie. In addition, there was the predicted interaction between

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Table 1 Perceived Gore and Meaningfulness as Predictors of Viewing Interest (Regression Models 1–4)

	Model 1 (Full Sample)	Model 2 (Not Seen)	Model 3 (Seen Before)	Model 4 (Full Sample)
Film Type				
	(Reference category: Film Type 2, horror)			
Film Type 1 (war drama)				.43***
Film Type 3 (drama)				.41***
Film Type 4 (action)				.44***
R^2				.19
F change				33.82***
Individual differences				
Age	−.09	.01	−.22**	−.09
Gender	−.02	−.05	−.03	.00
Education	−.06	−.04	−.13	−.05
Country (United States)	.11*	.06	.19**	.09*
Horror preference	.19***	.17*	.18*	.16***
R^2	.07	.04	.13	.24
F change	6.63***	2.08	5.32***	5.56***
Movie ratings (controls)				
Prior knowledge	.54***			.10**
Suspenseful	.70***	.59***	.60***	.59***
Frightening				−.21***
R^2	.43	.36	.45	.58
F change	137.17***	124.54***	105.72***	120.97***
Movie ratings (predictors)				
Gory	−.33***	−.36***	−.38***	−.16**
Meaningful	.22***	.26***	.15*	.21***
Gory × Meaningful	.15***	.15**	.11*	.11**
R^2	.60	.57	.59	.63
F change	59.50***	38.11***	20.84***	15.13***

*$p < .05$. **$p < .01$. ***$p < .001$.

anticipated gore and meaningfulness (H3). Simple slopes and Johnson–Neyman analyses of this interaction are reported following the results for the final regression model (Model 4).

Models 2 and 3: Follow-up of possible confounds with prior exposure

The finding in Model 1 that viewing interest varied as a function of prior exposure raised the possibility that the predictors of viewing interest might be dependent on whether or not participants had previously seen the movie advertised in the trailer. To examine whether perceived gore and meaningfulness predicted viewing interest in the same way for those who had as for those who had not seen the movie, we ran separate follow-up analyses within each subgroup.

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Model 2 was run on the subsample of participants who had not seen the movie before ($n = 286$); Model 3 on the subsample who had seen it before ($n = 196$). The variables entered in each step were identical with Model 1, except that prior exposure was not included in Step 2. Among those who had not seen the film before (Model 2), horror preference was the only significant individual difference predictor of viewing interest. Among those who had seen the film before (Model 3), age, country, and horror preference emerged as significant predictors, such that younger participants, Americans, and those with higher horror preference showed greater interest. In both subsamples, anticipated suspense was a significant positive predictor in Step 2. Finally, in Step 3, in both models, the same pattern of results emerged supporting our hypotheses: There was a negative main effect of perceived gore (H1), a positive main effect of perceived meaningfulness (H2), and a significant interaction effect of perceived gore and meaningfulness (H3) on viewing likelihood. Thus, the pattern of results supporting Hypotheses 1 through 3 did not seem to depend on whether or not the participants had previously seen the movie advertised in the trailer.

Model 4: Follow-up of possible confounds with film types

A fourth and final regression model was performed to consider the possible role of film types in creating this pattern of results. The four film types representing different levels of perceived gore and meaningfulness also represented different film genres. For example, both films of Type 1 (high gore, high meaning) dealt with war. Both films of Type 2 (high gore, low meaning) were horror films. Films of Type 3 (low gore, high meaning) were dramas, and films of Type 4 (low gore, low meaning) were action movies. Thus, it might be argued that the differences in viewing interest observed in regression Models 1 through 3 reflected judgments about those genres, rather than effects of anticipated gore and meaningfulness per se. Further, the stimulus check revealed nontrivial differences in ratings of gore and meaningfulness within levels of these variables. Notably, the difference in gore ratings between the two high-gore conditions, Film Type 1 and Film Type 2, was about 1 scale point. Thus, it might be argued that in addition to higher levels of perceived meaningfulness, the two war films also might have ranged below the threshold of gore that made the horror films in Film Type 2 intensely frightening and aversive.

To address these potential confounds, we included further control variables in Model 4. First, we entered dummy codes for film types, with Film Type 2 (horror films) as the reference category. This procedure allowed us to parcel out the amount of variance in viewing likelihood ratings that can be explained by the greater popularity of other film genres compared to horror movies (box office analyses indicate that the market share for horror films in the United States from 1995 to 2012 was only 4.77%, relative to the 20% market share for adventure, 18% for drama, and 17% share for action; Nash Information Service, 2013). In addition, ratings of anticipated fright reactions were entered in Step 2 to control for a possible confound of perceived meaning with lower levels of anticipated fright. This procedure allowed us to tease apart the variance in viewing interest explained by film types (including potential confounds

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with film genre, or anticipated fright reactions), and the variance explained by differences in individuals' perceptions of gore and meaningfulness as predicted in our hypotheses. If the relationships between gore and meaningfulness predicting viewing likelihood were replicated even controlling for film type, we would have stronger evidence for our argument that the pattern of results in Models 1 through 3 reflected judgments about gore and meaningfulness, rather than other, coincidental features of the content.

Based on these considerations, we ran a hierarchical regression analysis to predict ratings of viewing likelihood. In Step 1, we entered dummy codes for each film type, with Film Type 2 (horror films) as the reference category. As shown in Table 1, all other film types positively predicted ratings of viewing likelihood compared to Film Type 2 (horror films). In step 2, the individual difference variables (age, gender, education, country, and horror preference) were entered as additional controls. As in Model 1, country and horror preference emerged as significant predictors of viewing interest. In Step 3, we entered prior exposure to the film, anticipated suspense, and anticipated fright reactions. Prior exposure and anticipated suspense were significant positive predictors of viewing interest, whereas anticipated fright was a significant negative predictor. In the fourth and final step, we entered our focal predictors, that is, perceived levels of gore and meaningfulness and their interaction term. The same pattern of results supporting our hypotheses emerged again, despite the extended set of control variables including film types and anticipated fright reactions. There was a negative main effect of perceived gore (H1), a positive main effect of perceived meaningfulness (H2), and a significant interaction effect of perceived gore and meaningfulness (H3) on viewing likelihood.

Simple slopes analysis

To explicate the interaction effect of perceived gore and meaningfulness on viewing interest, we used Hayes' (2013) process macro to estimate the simple slopes of the relationship between perceived gore and viewing likelihood at three levels of perceived meaningfulness (at the mean, at 1 *SD* above the mean, and at 1 *SD* below the mean of perceived meaningfulness), including the same set of control variables as in Model 4. As shown in Figure 1, the negative influence of perceived gore on viewing likelihood was strongest at low levels of perceived meaningfulness (-1 *SD*: $\beta = -.26$, $p < .001$). The influence of perceived gore on viewing likelihood was weaker but still significant at average levels of perceived meaningfulness (mean: $\beta = -.16$, $p < .001$). However, at high levels of perceived meaningfulness, perceived gore had no significant influence on viewing likelihood ($+1$ *SD*: $\beta = -.06$, $p > .05$). This pattern of results adds further support to our argument that the negative effect of gore on viewing likelihood is mitigated at high levels of perceived meaningfulness.

Johnson–Neyman analysis

To determine the critical moderator value of perceived meaningfulness where the negative influence of perceived gore on viewing interest turned insignificant, we

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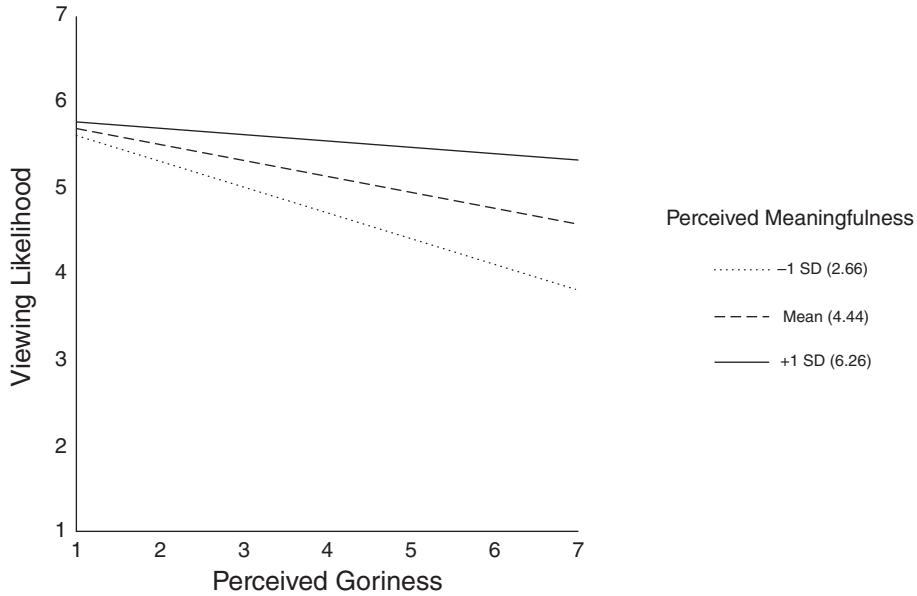

Figure 1 Simple slopes analysis of the interaction effect of perceptions of gore and meaningfulness on viewing likelihood. *Note*: Simple slopes reflect the influence of perceived gore on viewing likelihood at different levels of perceived meaningfulness, controlling for age, gender, education, country, horror preference, prior exposure to the film, and ratings of anticipated suspense and fright. Regression weights of the simple slopes are reported in the main text.

performed a Johnson–Neyman analysis using Hayes' (2013) process macro. Ratings of viewing likelihood were entered as the dependent variable, ratings of perceived gore as the focal predictor, and ratings of perceived meaningfulness as the moderator, with the same set of control variables as in regression Model 4. The critical moderator value of perceived meaningfulness that distinguished between a significant negative and a nonsignificant influence of perceived gore on viewing likelihood was 5.49 scale points (on a scale from 1 to 7; $M = 4.4$; $SD = 1.80$). About one third of the sample (32%) gave ratings of perceived meaningfulness above this critical moderator value that rendered the influence of perceived goriness inconsequential for viewing interest.

Discussion

This study sought to extend prior research on the appeals and functions of violent media content, by focusing on a viewing motive—the anticipation of meaningful and thought-provoking experiences—that has not previously been considered in this context. Recent theorizing and research on eudaimonic attractions to sad content indicates that individuals sometimes choose to watch content that they do not expect to enjoy, but that offers other rewards, such as the opportunity to wrestle with negative experiences in their own life, or in the world in general, and to reflect on

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what really matters in life (Knobloch-Westerwick et al., 2013; Oliver, 2008; Oliver & Bartsch, 2010; Oliver & Hartmann, 2010; Wirth et al., 2012). The current study built on those insights by examining whether individuals may override their aversion to scenes of graphic gore and decide to see a film despite the presence of such content, if they anticipate that the depiction of violence will elicit eudaimonic, meaning-making responses.

We began by asking pretest audiences to rate film trailers in terms of how gory each film appeared to be, and whether they thought that the depiction of violence in the film would be meaningful and thought-provoking. We then selected trailers that were rated high or low in gore, and high or low in meaningfulness, but that were equivalent in suspense. Participants in the main study were then assigned to see and rate one of these four types of trailers.

As expected, perceptions of goriness per se tended to detract from viewing interest (H1). However, consistent with recent findings about attractions to sad dramas (Oliver, 2008; Wirth et al., 2012), participants gave higher ratings of viewing likelihood to films that they expected to deal with issues of violence in meaningful ways (H2). Moreover, as predicted in our core hypothesis (H3), the anticipated presence of meaning in violent portrayals seemed to moderate the aversive effect of gore on viewing interest. Results of the simple slopes analysis and the Johnson–Neyman analysis conducted to explicate this interaction indicated that the generally negative influence of perceived gore on viewing interest was no longer significant at high levels of perceived meaningfulness. That is, participants who thought that the depiction of violence in the movie would be meaningful, moving, and thought-provoking expressed high likelihood of viewing, regardless of the anticipated amount of gore. About one third of the sample gave ratings above the critical moderator value of perceived meaningfulness that reduced the influence of gore to nonsignificance. Considering the diversity of the sample of participants from different countries, age groups, and educational levels, and the diversity of the stimulus sample including films from different mainstream genres, these findings provide strong indication that meaning-making plays a common and consequential role in motivating exposure to violent content.

Further evidence of the robustness of this preference for meaningfulness came from a comparative analysis of those who had and those who had not seen the film before. We chose real, extant trailers for U.S. or British films that were internationally popular enough to be translated into German. This meant that over one third of the sample had already seen the film, providing an additional, naturally occurring comparison. In fact, the same pattern of preferences emerged among those who had already seen the film before as among those who were relying solely on the themes and images highlighted in the trailer (see Models 2 and 3).

Additional follow-up analyses indicate that the pattern of results was not reducible to the variance explained by the four film types included in the stimulus sample (horror, action, drama, and war films). Particular care was taken to rule out the alternative explanation that the pattern of results might be driven by individuals' lesser liking

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of the horror genre per se, or by the fact that horror films tend to be more frightening than other genres. To address these alternative explanations, anticipated fright reactions and dummy codes controlling for more favorable ratings of other film types compared to horror films were included as additional control variables in our final regression model (Model 4). Again, the pattern of results supporting our hypotheses was robust, with the extended set of control variables. Thus, it seems unlikely that the interaction effect of perceived gore and meaningfulness on viewing interest was entirely driven by individuals' aversion of horror films, or other possible cofounds associated with film genre.

Although there are undoubtedly individual differences in what is considered meaningful, the results of the pretest and the stimulus check suggest that these were not wholly idiosyncratic judgments. If they were, we would not have found consistent differences in ratings of meaningfulness between film types—rather we would only have found prediction of viewing likelihood by individuals' subjective ratings of anticipated meaningfulness. This consistency in ratings of meaningfulness raises several crucial questions that remain unaddressed by this study. What did people mean when they rated their expectation that the portrayal of violence in a given movie would be meaningful, moving, and thought-provoking? What sorts of thoughts did they anticipate having, and what was it about the trailers that connoted meaningfulness?

As noted in the introduction, meaning-making has been described by some theorists as a process of dissonance reduction, or coping with negative experiences that violate individuals' belief in a just world (e.g., Anderson & Kay, 2013; Park, 2010). In the absence of material compensation for the victim, the process of dissonance reduction is assumed to focus on immaterial rewards such as greater insight, social connection, and personal growth. This description of immaterial goods that can compensate individuals for material loss and pain is consistent with theories of eudaimonic well-being (Ryff & Singer, 2008; Waterman, 1993), and with descriptions of salient themes of media content that was rated as "meaningful" by viewers. For example, a qualitative analysis of Oliver and Hartmann (2010) found a number of recurrent themes in film viewers' descriptions of meaningful movies—including the appreciation of human life as fleeting and precious, the value of human connection and mutual support, and the importance of human virtue, endurance, and keeping faith during times of hardship and challenge.

In this study, we assessed perceived meaningfulness of violent portrayals in the broadest possible sense by adapting Oliver and Bartsch's (2010) measure of eudaimonic appreciation that asks whether the content is perceived as "meaningful," "moving," and "thought-provoking." An important next step is to link this global measure of eudaimonic appreciation to the perception of specific content features that should arouse and satisfy a need for meaning-making, according to theoretical assumptions (Anderson & Kay, 2013; Park, 2010). For example, future research may ask more specifically about acts of violence that violate the viewers' just-world beliefs, and about the compensation of victims in terms of immaterial rewards such as

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deeper insight, social connectedness, and personal growth. The qualitative findings of Oliver and Hartmann (2010) may provide further specification of abstract notions such as "personal growth" by linking them to more concrete examples of human virtue, endurance, and faith as described in viewers' accounts of meaningful movie experiences.

Further experimental work, manipulating unfamiliar media content to add or subtract these key features, may provide additional insight into the process of meaning-making and eudaimonic appreciation in the context of media violence. Using edited versions of unfamiliar content to create more controlled stimulus conditions could also help to avoid some of the confounds with prior exposure and genre that we encountered in this study. Thus, this finding of an interaction effect of perceived gore and meaningfulness on viewing interest could be replicated and extended in an experimental setting.

Theories of meaning-making also draw attention to alternative ways of dissonance reduction that can short-circuit the need for meaning-making. For example, individuals' belief in a just world may also be restored by focusing on material compensation of the victim, or by blaming the victim for his or her fate (Anderson & Kay, 2013; Karuza & Carey, 1984). Both forms of dissonance reduction have been linked to hedonic enjoyment in the media violence literature. Some violent genres such as action and adventure movies frequently end with material compensation for the victim and punishment for the perpetrator—a pattern of outcomes that leads to hedonic enjoyment, according to affective disposition theory (Raney & Bryant, 2002). Horror films often do not offer such "happy endings," but seem to encourage attribution of blame to the victim. For example, research has found that female characters who get killed are often portrayed as sexually permissive or otherwise morally flawed (Cowan & O'Brien, 1990), and that a punitive attitude of "watching them get what they deserve" predicts enjoyment of this type of content (Oliver, 1993). Thus, some types of violent portrayals seem to encourage meaning-making, whereas other types of portrayals invite more hedonistic forms of dissonance reduction. Research on both hedonic and eudaimonic motivations for viewing violence could therefore profit from an integrated assessment of narrative structures in terms of different strategies of dissonance reduction and related viewing motivations.

Future research could also profit from extending the scope to other possible types of nonhedonic motives for exposure to violent media content. For example, research of Tamborini, Bowman, Eden, Grizzard, and Organ (2010) based on self-determination theory (Ryan & Deci, 2000) has drawn attention to the relevance of individuals' needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness as predictors of media enjoyment. In addition, recent work of Tamborini, Eden, Bowman, Grizzard, and Lachlan (2012) highlights the role of individuals' moral values in shaping their acceptance and enjoyment of media violence. Thus, the focus of this study on individuals' search for meaning in certain types of violent portrayals might be fruitfully complemented with research that examines the possible role of these other types of nonhedonic needs in motivating exposure to violent content.

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There are additional limitations of this study that are important to note. As already mentioned, these findings require replication using edited versions of unfamiliar content to create more controlled stimulus conditions that would allow for experimental comparisons. The results are also limited by the use of a self-report measure of viewing interest, namely individuals' reported likelihood of viewing the movie. In Weaver's (2011) meta-analysis, the effects of violence on selective exposure were consistent across studies using attitudinal and behavioral measures. Nevertheless, further validation using behavioral data is important to substantiate the current results. Finally, although the sample was larger and more diverse than most samples employed in research on audience interest in violent content, there was an educational bias in both national subsamples. In the absence of a significant influence of education as a control variable, this bias did not seem to compromise the results. However, to convince media producers that the level of blood and gore is counterproductive to audience attraction if there is no meaningful purpose in confronting these disturbing images, further research using representative samples would be helpful.

With these limitations and desiderata for future research in mind, we think that the results of this study are encouraging—in particular because they suggest that producers could profitably focus on meaning-making and eudaimonic appreciation as a strategy for increasing audience appeal, rather than escalating the level of blood and gore per se. Moreover, given the self-reflective and contemplative nature of eudaimonic entertainment experiences (Bartsch, 2012; Oliver & Bartsch, 2011; Oliver & Hartmann, 2010; Oliver et al., 2012) these findings hint at the potential fruitfulness of examining whether some types of violent portrayals may actually have prosocial outcomes. Perhaps, depictions of violence that are perceived as moving and thought-provoking can foster empathy with victims, admiration for acts of courage, and moral beauty in the face of violence, or self-reflection with regard to violent impulses. Examining the prevalence of such responses and the conditions under which they occur offers a theoretically intriguing and socially valuable direction for further work.

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